

The Gazette Looking back

100 years ago — January 5, 1894

Monday's *Globe* gave us the following notice: "The Almonte Gazette got out a sixteen page paper at Christmas. The issue had a good supply of holiday literature, an interesting chapter of The Gazette's history of Lanark County, and much seasonable local matter. Perhaps no weekly paper in the Province is showing greater vigor and enterprise than The Gazette. It stands now in the very front rank of Canadian weeklies."

The high school reopened on Wednesday, with a large attendance. Some of the rooms have about as many pupils as can be accommodated. Miss Clark, the new assistant, arrived on Tuesday. The public school departments all opened with a good attendance.

Miss Annie Naismith and Mr. P. J. Young have just returned from a three weeks jaunt among relatives at Springfield, Mass., and Montreal.

Among those who successfully passed their Christmas examinations in McGill, we are pleased to notice the names of Messrs. J. C. Watt, Stephen and Henry Young and C. Bates.

50 years ago — January 6, 1944

In an advertisement which appears elsewhere in this issue the Lanark & Carleton Counties Telephone Co. warns its subscribers that a dry battery shortage is imminent.

Without dry batteries telephones cannot be operated so the people who want to continue their service should do everything in their power to conserve the energy hooked on to their local systems.

One way of doing this is to confine conversations to essentials.

Gossip is one of the things that runs down battery strength on the telephone. Town subscribers are bad enough but it is much worse in the country. There, distances are greater and it is impossible for Mrs. Podunk to communicate over the back fence, or out the back window, with her neighbor Mrs. Gablecronk. She must use the telephone in order to tell about the pickles that didn't turn out right or ask for a recipe which is, in reality, an excuse for getting into a long conversation about local trivialities.

The organization meeting of the Town Council was held on Tuesday night. Mayor Scott appointed a striking committee to name the standing committees for the year, composed of the following: Dunlop, Morton and Scissons.

Finance — Morton, Wrigglesworth and Pimlott.

Fire and Town Property — Pimlott, Scissons and Morton.

Roads and Bridges — Dunlop, Pierce and Whitten.

Contingent and Printing — Wrigglesworth, Scissons and Dunlop.

Waterworks — Whitten, Scissons and Pierce.

Police — Pierce, Morton and Scissons.

10 years ago — January 4, 1984

It was a busy month for area snow plow and ski hill operators with heavy December snowfalls eating up the remainder of Almonte's snow removal budget and initiating the winter of 1983.

"It's been an exceptional year so far," said Don Dodd, of DGS Contracting. "In the last two years there hasn't been that much snow."

Although for years wolf bounties have been illegal in this part of the country, Lanark county council continues to pay out approximately \$3,000 a year to hunters and trappers bagging coyotes.

In fact, more money may have to be budgeted for bounties this winter, as \$2,500 has already been paid out to the end of November, 1983.

The town of Almonte will join other municipalities across the province next year in implementing a new accounting system. On motion of council at their inaugural meeting, the town entered into agreement with the ministry of municipal affairs and housing for the implementation of the Basic Accounting Package.

The package, a new format established to standardize the accounting practices of municipalities across the province, will be put into practice next summer with a 1985 target date for complete conversion.

The Almonte Ringette Association hosted its annual tournament last week, and most home teams showed ample reasons why they are well respected in their leagues.

The Tweens won the 'A' title and captured top honors at the Ottawa Invitational tournament.

Columns

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Pic of the Past

Forty-four years have passed since these children were in Miss Edna Ross's Grade 4 class at the Church Street School: (back row) Bobbie Morrow, Jackie Schouler, Gordon Donaldson, Alexander Brown, Wayne Dugdale, Delbert Barr, Jackie Dalgity, Sandy France, Allen Gilmour, Laurie McPhail, (third row) Doreen Peaver, Margaret Wilson, Jane Smithson, Doreen Leach, Isobel Morrow, Betty

Stewart, Marilyn Spinks, Gayle Smithson, Carmel Ring, (second row) Lyn Grand, Ann McClymont, Shirley Lotan, Donna Simpson, Miss Ross, Sylvia Sinnett, Gayle Mohr, Sandra Elliott, (front row) Donnie Rodger, Alfred Buffin, Frank Hirst, Raymond Ford, Stanley Conley, Tom Miller, Garry Phillips and Eric Campbell. The photo belongs to Eileen Barr.

Squirrels can't all be stopped at feeders

If you enjoy feeding wild birds in winter, it is never too early (or late), to begin planning — planning how you will keep hordes of squirrels from bankrupting you before spring, that is.

Outwitting a mob of wily bird feeder-raiding bushytails can be one of life's great challenges.

People who have never faced the challenge often refuse to believe the brilliance of the stratagems these varmints are capable of when presented with the opportunity of a bird feeder filled with sunflower seed.

Or the aggression.

I've seen a hungry squirrel challenge grown men trying to chase it from a feeder. Ordinary house cats present little obstacle.

One grizzled old veteran squirrel who fed at my feeder when I lived in the city feared no cat. I had a smallish yard there, which I was able to squirrel-proof except for this old master.

He (there was no doubt of his gender) was so resourceful I finally accepted defeat with as much grace as I could muster and counted the entertainment worth the price.

One day's show convinced me.

My yard had a small landing from where I could hang laundry to dry on a clothesline. The rail around that landing was just barely too great a squirrel-leap to my feeder located dead-centre of the yard —

The Wolf Grove Diary

By John Fowler

except, of course, for the individual in question.

One dreary December day the squirrel was at lunch when the largest, meanest tomcat of the neighborhood took up a challenging position on the rail.

The intent was clear. And the squirrel was disturbed.

Not fearful — but clearly stressed by the unwelcome psychological pressure obviously roiling the digestive juices.

After all, if the squirrel could, might not the cat also be capable of making that leap?

Threatening gestures and volumes of squirrel epithets proved of no avail. Cat simply crouched even more tensely, gathering muscles with increasing resolve.

Prompt resolution of this standoff became imperative. That resolution came as a wondrous surprise both to cat and me, and possibly to squirrel as well.

The squirrel crouched, tensing his own muscles, then launched into a swift leap

directly at cat. The cat's surprise was so great he barely had time to begin to draw back one forepaw before squirrel landed directly on cat's back, all claws and teeth sunk sharply into cat's hide.

Both disappeared in a wail of shrieks.

Not long after, squirrel returned, none the worse for wear. But cat never entered my yard again.

Help is available

If you need help keeping squirrels from your feeder, there are things that can be done.

If you have space, you can suspend your feeder well above ground, and well away from trees or other structures from which squirrels can leap to the feeder.

It will be necessary to place obstructions on the suspension cables each side of the feeder; old 33 rpm records work well, or other circular items of similar size.

Pole-mounting the feeder is usually most convenient for most installations.



Letters

From page 4

Financially, this would permit couples in homosexual relationships to have all the benefits currently enjoyed by married couples, including the right to medical and pension benefits, adoption rights and even the right to legally marry.

Alarming as the foregoing may be, here is another "gem of wisdom." The Human Rights Code defines harassment as: "engaging in a course of vexatious comment or conduct that is known or ought reasonably to be known to be unwelcome."

This definition is so vague that any criticism of the homosexual lifestyle, merely saying that one dislikes it, could be construed as harassment under Bill 45.

Everyone, including homosexuals, enjoys freedom from discrimination in the law right now. If these changes are made in the Code, it would give special privileges to a special interest group based on their behavior.

Surely, the time has arrived to say "Enough is enough!" Let the reader know that the only political party in Ontario speaking out against this Bill is the Family Coalition Party, the sole alternative to what is happening at Queen's Park.

Yours truly,
Stan Callaghan
President, Family Coalition Party
Lanark-Renfrew

Help! We need
your old pictures
for Pic of the Past.

Cold fingers counted birds at Christmas

The Carleton Place Christmas Bird Count for 1993 was one of the coldest I can remember, with starting temperature -31C.

Needless to say, most of the counting was done from the car and walking confined to short distances on the roads. Although we did manage 15 species, our number of birds was less than half of what we usually get.

The next day, (Tuesday), Lynda and I along with Georgina Doe, took part in the Rideau Ferry Count and the weather was much more "user-friendly" with starting temperature reading -20. Our count area was a triangle pointed on Richardson, Port Elmsley and Perth and we found twenty species and counted 621 individuals.

Strangest of these was a robin along with a cedar waxwing, eating buckthorn berries. On both counts, raptors were scarce for us although others registered several species. You can read about the Carleton Place Count results elsewhere in this issue.

The Canada goose, noted at the foot of the falls in Almonte, has survived the cold snap. It was reported by Brad Jones, on Thursday, along with a common merganser and again on Sunday by Max McConnell. Possibly injured and unable to fly, it is surviving in its greatly diminished water area by reaching down for whatever plant life it can grab. I haven't heard of anyone successfully getting feed to it.

I saw it Christmas Day floating like a piece of garbage, its head tucked under its wing, amongst the ice pans created by the falling water. Max noted the bird

Strictly for the Birds

By Cliff Bennett 256-5013



often is out on the ice.

As you will see from the Bird Count report by Mike Jaques, a record number of 52 cardinals were recorded. I would have been disappointed if this were not the case for the cardinal registry I have been keeping has grown to 120. Latest reports come from a new reader George Duck, Carleton Place, who counted six at his feeders on Monday; Betty Houston, Smiths Falls, Cecil Roy, Ramsay 8th line (he also listed six), Faye Martin, Prospect, and Eleanor McRae, Clayton Road.

George Duck, who moved to Carleton Place in November from Britannia, where he always had cardinals, gained immediate success when he established his feeders. I wonder if they followed him

from Britannia. Ursula Brown, Ashton area called just now to report she has six cardinals.

In other bird news, Ursula Brown noted a male cowbird at her feeder for the past three days. Cowbirds should be well south of here by now. Ursula also reported 14 regular mourning doves and lots of woodpeckers.

Faye Martin counted a pair of male pine grosbeaks and Barb Watson, Carleton, related spying the sharp-shinned hawk on Bird Count day.

Barbara and Jim Blair, Almonte, watched a stranger trying to perch on the tip of a cedar tree in Gemmill Park, Saturday. At first they thought it was a large owl but couldn't find it in their small identification book. They described it as having wide wings and tail, much larger than a crow, mixed brown with a bit of white on the under wings and having no ear tufts. Has anyone else spotted this one in the area?

Redpolls are becoming the common new visitor to the feeders. Barb Watson opened her blind onto a window feeder and found redpolls only six inches from her.

At first, they are difficult to identify and appear as small sparrows. Looking closer, they are pale brown streaked with

a dark red skull cap. The male has a pink brushed breast.

These little seed eaters breed in the tundra of our Arctic wilderness and come south in the winter to feed on the weeds sticking out from the snow. When the snow covers their food source, they come in to our feeders.

They like small seeds and bits of chewed up sunflower seeds. They appear in large flocks at first, attacking any seed bearing area. Pouncing on the dead plants, they shake the seeds onto the snow before feeding.

These birds are quite tame and trusting, making them vulnerable to house cats and other predator. Maggie Arnott, Beckwith, Ursula Brown and Eleanor McRae also reported redpolls at their feeders.

Year's highlights

1993 highlights, as gleaned from your reports, make interesting reading. There were 272 different people-reported sightings, averaging over four times each. One hundred and fifty-four different species were reported, down eighteen from 1992.

Eagles, both golden and bald, were confirmed; a few great blue herons didn't migrate and froze during the early winter many robins stayed over and didn't freeze; warbler sightings were well down; we seemed to have a good year for bluebirds and certainly for cardinals and the seasonal migration, both ways, unfolded normally.

The real success of this column is the offering of a forum for people interested in birds, to call up and talk to someone.

